

ENGLISH FOR WORK / SEPTEMBER 2026

Childcare and Early Education English



Vocabulary & phrasebook

Keep precise meanings and useful expressions close. Retrieve the words, then use them in a complete message.

PRACTICE THAT TRANSFERS TO WORK

Read a realistic case. Study complete conversations. Find the right language, speak, get feedback, and try again.

Eight lessons | Intermediate to advanced | Independent or classroom study

For Childcare workers, early educators, classroom assistants, and preschool support staff.

All children, families, observations, times, and center arrangements are fictional English practice. This is not medical, developmental-diagnostic, safeguarding, legal, nutrition, staffing-ratio, or emergency-response training. Real care plans, supervision, collection authority, reporting duties, and health or protection concerns require current local rules and the center's qualified leadership. Do not infer universal age expectations, clinical advice, or permission to release a child from these exercises. Role titles vary: key educator may be called key person or primary caregiver; designated safeguarding lead means this fictional center's named child-protection contact, not a universal U.S. role. Reasonable adjustment and reasonable accommodation are regional terms with jurisdiction-specific meanings and responsibilities.

All scenarios, figures, and model responses are fictional teaching material. Use invented details in practice.

[Open this course on English Ladder](#)

Make vocabulary usable

Knowing a definition is a start. To use a term well, explain it in plain English, connect it to a case, and choose a natural sentence around it.

- Read five terms, cover their definitions, and recall the meanings.
- Sort a pair you might confuse and explain the difference.
- Use one term in a sentence about a fictional case.
- Ask a partner to explain the sentence without repeating the specialist word.
- Return to the same terms on another day and test recall again.

Abbreviations need context

Expand an abbreviation on first use when the listener needs it. Some abbreviations have different meanings across professions: API can refer to an application programming interface or an active pharmaceutical ingredient. The course context determines the meaning.

Definitions have limits

These are concise language-learning explanations, not complete legal, clinical, or technical specifications. Use the applicable authoritative definition for regulated or operational decisions.

Field vocabulary A-Z

allergy care plan

The child's documented, individually agreed arrangements for managing a known allergy within the setting.

attendance register

The setting's record of children's presence and relevant arrival or departure information.

authorized collector

A person whose permission to collect a particular child has been established under the setting's requirements.

child-initiated play

Play whose idea or direction begins with the child rather than being assigned by an adult.

co-regulation

Supportive adult interaction that helps a child manage feelings and behavior while developing self-regulation.

comfort item

A familiar object that a child finds reassuring, used according to the setting's arrangements.

communication preference

A family's or child's preferred way of sharing and receiving information.

designated safeguarding lead

A title used in some settings for the named child-protection contact coordinating concerns under local requirements; not a universal U.S. job title or a replacement for individuals' reporting duties.

developmental milestone

A commonly described skill or behavior associated with development, not a diagnosis or universal timetable for an individual child.

developmental screening

A structured process used by appropriately qualified people to identify whether closer developmental review may be needed.

family handover

An exchange of relevant information between a family member and staff when care responsibility changes.

guided play

Play that retains children's active choices while an educator offers prompts or support toward a learning purpose.

health coordinator

The person designated by the setting to coordinate relevant health information and questions within their role.

home language

A language used in a child's family or home life, which may be one of several.

incident record

The setting's factual documentation of an event, responses, contacts, and follow-up.

inclusion plan

The setting's agreed support arrangements for a child's participation, developed with relevant people.

key educator

The staff member designated to support a child's continuity of care and family communication; called a key person or primary caregiver in some settings.

learning portfolio

A collection of selected observations and work showing a child's experiences and learning over time.

observation note

A factual record of what an educator saw or heard in a stated context.

open-ended question

A question inviting explanation, exploration, or several possible answers rather than one fixed response.

peer conflict

A disagreement between children that needs understanding and appropriate support.

reasonable adjustment

A regional term for a change supporting access or participation; U.S. settings often use reasonable accommodation, with meaning and obligations depending on applicable local requirements.

repair attempt

An action or message intended to address the effect of a disagreement or mistake.

safeguarding concern

Information suggesting a child's welfare or protection may need attention through the required pathway.

scaffolding

Temporary support that helps a child do or understand something without taking over the task.

self-help skill

An everyday action a child is learning to manage with increasing independence and suitable support.

settling-in period

The time during which a child and family become familiar with a new early-education setting.

transition

The change from one activity, place, or part of the day to another.

transition cue

A consistent signal that an activity change is approaching or beginning.

turn-taking

Sharing participation or access through successive turns.

visual schedule

A sequence of pictures or symbols showing planned parts of the day.

witness account

A description from a person who directly saw or heard an event.

Expressions for this course

Complete the frames with the facts of your case. A frame helps organize meaning; it should not replace an actual explanation.

Clarify arrival expectations with the family

You expected ____; our note says ____.

Let's check today's settling-in plan with ____.

What helped ____ feel familiar yesterday?

Acknowledge the parent's expectation and address the child warmly. Agree what happens today without making a guarantee about tears or separation. Do not treat one difficult arrival as evidence about the family. Some settings call the key educator a key person or primary caregiver; check the center's own role names.

Word combinations in this lesson

greet the child by name: address the child directly at arrival

share a morning update: pass relevant information from home to the educator

agree a goodbye routine: establish a predictable parting arrangement with the family

check the settling-in plan: review the current agreed arrival support

Invite thinking without taking over the play

What would you like your ____ to do?

How could you test ____?

You suggested ____; what does your partner think?

An open-ended question invites more than a guessed adult answer. Scaffolding offers enough help to continue while leaving meaningful choices with children. Adult language can be clear without directing every action.

Word combinations in this lesson

follow the child's interest: build a conversation from what the child is exploring

offer a small prompt: give limited support without taking over

extend the play: invite a new idea that builds on the child's activity

leave room for an answer: allow time for the child to respond in their own way

Offer a real choice inside a clear routine

___ begins in ___; you can choose ___ or ___.

First ___, then ___.

Your ___ can stay ___ while we ___.

A bounded choice gives meaningful options while keeping the known routine explicit. Use before and after carefully. Do not threaten, shame, or promise unlimited extra time.

Word combinations in this lesson

give a transition cue: signal that the next activity is approaching

check the visual schedule: refer to the pictures showing the day's sequence

offer a bounded choice: provide a small set of real options within the routine

allow time to finish: give the agreed opportunity to bring an activity to a stopping point

Describe the disagreement without choosing a villain

I saw ___; I don't yet know ___.

You wanted ___, and your friend wanted ___.

What could help us put ___ right?

Use observed actions, not claims about motives or character. Co-regulation includes calm language and time to respond. A repair attempt should address the effect; a forced apology alone may not clarify the problem.

Word combinations in this lesson

name the feeling tentatively: offer a possible feeling word without claiming to know the child's mind

describe the observed action: say what happened without labeling the child's character

support turn-taking: help children agree and understand whose turn comes next

invite a repair attempt: support a practical response to the effect on another child

Share the achievement without inflating the conclusion

During ___, I saw/heard ___.

This shows ___ in that activity; it doesn't establish ___.

We can compare this with observations from ___.

Give the action, words, and context. Milestones and screening are not interchangeable with a single classroom observation. Do not diagnose, rank, or make universal age claims.

Word combinations in this lesson

anchor an observation in context: state when and where an action occurred

quote the child's words: preserve a short accurate example of what the child said

compare observations over time: look at dated evidence rather than a single impression

raise a developmental question: invite the appropriate review without diagnosing a child

Recognize participation without overstating what it shows

Both formats let the child ____; only ____ shows ____.

The agreed plan allows ____, and today's preference is ____.

What communication arrangement works for your family?

Different response formats can support the same activity while showing different skills. Home language is an asset. Reasonable adjustment is regional wording; U.S. settings often say reasonable accommodation. Meanings and duties vary by location. Discuss this center's agreed inclusion plan, not a universal legal entitlement.

Word combinations in this lesson

invite home-language knowledge: welcome words or information the family chooses to share

check the agreed adjustment: confirm the current participation support rather than inventing one

adapt the participation format: offer an agreed way to join the activity

ask about communication preferences: establish how the family wants information shared

Transfer the plan discrepancy without inventing care instructions

The family reports ____; the current document says ____.

I witnessed ____; ____ was reported by ____.

____ has accepted the plan/documentation query.

A family's report is important, but a possible change is not a verified care instruction. Actual health concerns require the center's real response arrangements. This lesson gives no food substitution, medication, first-aid, or emergency directions.

Word combinations in this lesson

check the current care plan: identify the plan presently applicable to the child

report an observed change: describe what staff noticed without assigning a diagnosis

separate witnessed from reported: distinguish direct observation from another person's account

confirm the family notification: establish whether the relevant family contact actually occurred

Hold the collection boundary calmly

Today's collection authority is not yet ____.

____ can check the arrangement while ____ remains ____.

I can listen, but I cannot promise to keep a protection concern from ____.

Familiarity is not verified collection authority. In this fictional center, designated safeguarding lead names its child-protection contact; it is not a universal U.S. title. Follow actual local protection and reporting duties. Never promise absolute secrecy, investigate independently, or assume handing a concern to a lead replaces an individual's reporting responsibilities.

Word combinations in this lesson

verify collection arrangements: check that the adult may collect the particular child

complete a collection handover: exchange the relevant information as care responsibility changes

raise a safeguarding concern: bring relevant welfare information to the required responsible route

limit disclosure to the relevant people: protect information while meeting applicable reporting responsibilities

Model responses in context

Read the situation first. Cover the model, say your own response, and compare the two for meaning and tone.

01 | Arrivals and family partnerships

It is Mina's third morning. Her parent expected to stay for ten minutes, but the arrival note says a brief goodbye. Key educator Rosa is present and can clarify the settling-in plan with the parent. Mina has a familiar cloth; its use follows the center's arrangements.

You expected ten minutes together, while our arrival note says a brief goodbye. Let's check that difference with Rosa, Mina's key educator, before describing today's plan. Mina, you brought your cloth. Let's talk to Rosa together before you say goodbye.

Try it again: Ask for a promise that Mina will not cry after goodbye.

AI extension: build and retrieve vocabulary from this case.

02 | Play-based learning and useful prompts

In fictional block play, Eva and Jo each want their bridge design used. Eva wants a wide bridge; Jo wants a taller opening. The educator can invite both explanations and suggest trying two designs using available blocks. No winner has been chosen.

Eva, you want a wider bridge; Jo, you want a taller opening. Let's hear what each design would help you do. We have enough blocks to try both ideas, so we don't need to choose a winner first. Tell each other what you want to test, and then decide which design to build first together.

Try it again: Ask the educator to name the best design before either has been tried.

AI extension: build and retrieve vocabulary from this case.

03 | Daily routines and supported transitions

Luca is building when the room moves to story time in five minutes. The center's current arrangement allows his structure to remain on the marked shelf. He can choose to place the last block or ask the educator to photograph the work using the center's permitted practice. The educator cannot extend play indefinitely.

Luca, story time begins in five minutes. You can place your last block, or we can make a record of your building using our classroom photo arrangement. The structure can stay on the marked shelf. Which would help you finish for now? We will still join the story when the transition cue sounds.

Try it again: Ask for ten more minutes when only five are available.

AI extension: build and retrieve vocabulary from this case.

04 | Co-regulation and peer disagreements

Two children reach for the same large scoop. The educator saw Ari holding it, then Bea reaching; motive is unknown. A smaller scoop is available. Ari wants to finish one container. Bea wants the large scoop next. No injury or ongoing danger is stated.

Ari, you were holding the large scoop; Bea, you reached for it and want a turn. Let's hear what each of you needs. Ari wants to finish one container, and Bea wants the next turn. The smaller scoop is available meanwhile. Can we agree on that order and check that both of you understand it?

Try it again: A child insists that wanting the same toy proves the other child was being mean.

AI extension: build and retrieve vocabulary from this case.

05 | Observation and family progress conversations

Today educator Rosa saw Eli sort four buttons by color during a supervised activity and heard 'these go together.' A parent asks whether this proves Eli is ahead of every child his age. No comparison data or developmental screening is supplied.

Today Eli grouped four buttons by color and said, 'These go together.' That is a useful observation of this activity, but it does not establish how he compares with every child his age. We can include the context in his learning portfolio and discuss observations over time rather than turn one moment into a developmental ranking.

Try it again: Ask the educator to give a diagnostic label based only on the observation.

AI extension: build and retrieve vocabulary from this case.

06 | Inclusive participation and home languages

A small-group story can use picture choices or spoken answers. Child Noor's current inclusion plan allows either. Noor prefers pointing today. A colleague treats pointing as nonparticipation. The educator can explain what both formats allow without claiming identical language evidence.

Noor's inclusion plan allows picture choices or spoken answers. Both let Noor indicate a story choice, but they do not provide the same evidence of spoken English. Today Noor prefers pointing. We can recognize that participation and keep the distinction clear, instead of treating a different response format as no response at all.

Try it again: Ask whether the same inclusion plan should automatically apply to every child.

AI extension: build and retrieve vocabulary from this case.

07 | Health records and factual incident handovers

A parent tells educator Rosa that child Theo's allergy plan may have changed. The center still has the earlier plan; no revised document is supplied. No food decision, exposure, symptoms, or emergency is part of this case. Health coordinator Amira is present and accepts the document query.

Amira, Theo's parent reports a possible change to the allergy care plan, but we still have the earlier document and no revised plan. Could you clarify that with the family and the relevant qualified professional? I have not described the reported change as confirmed or made a food decision. Please confirm that you are taking this plan query.

Try it again: A colleague wants to infer a food decision from the parent's incomplete message.

AI extension: build and retrieve vocabulary from this case.

08 | Collection, confidentiality, and safeguarding communication

An unfamiliar adult says they are Nia's uncle and came instead of the usual collector. Today's collection authority is not verified. Lead educator Rosa is available to check the arrangement. The child has not been released. No legal document or family relationship is established by the adult's statement.

I understand you have come to collect Nia, but today's collection arrangement has not been verified. Rosa can check it with you through the center's collection process. We cannot treat knowing Nia or stating a family relationship as the completed check. Nia will remain with the staff while that question is resolved.

Try it again: Point out that Nia recognizes you and ask whether that completes the check.

AI extension: build and retrieve vocabulary from this case.

Use the language responsibly

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Meaning before performance

Use specialist terms only when they help the listener. Explain unfamiliar words, preserve uncertainty, and ask when an instruction or responsibility is unclear. The model responses illustrate language; they do not authorize professional actions.

Sources and further reading

The cases, workshops, and explanations are original teaching material. These references provide language frameworks and selected professional context. References were checked in September 2026; consult current local guidance for actual work.

Digital.gov: plain-language guidance

<https://digital.gov/guides/plain-language>

Council of Europe: CEFR descriptors

<https://www.coe.int/en/web/common-european-framework-reference-languages/cefr-descriptors>

U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics: Childcare Workers

<https://www.bls.gov/ooh/personal-care-and-service/childcare-workers.htm>

National Association for the Education of Young Children: Principles of Child Development and Learning

<https://www.naeyc.org/resources/position-statements/dap/principles>

Your next step

Choose one expression you can use in a genuine work situation. Rehearse it with fictional details, then adapt the wording to your role and audience.

Extend your practice with AI

Use the next two prompts after your own first attempt. Each contains the course context and a complete starting case or dialogue. Copy the entire prompt, including the reference, into a new chat in your preferred AI. You can also use the links to copy it from the website.

Choose the right kind of help

A role-play prompt makes the AI wait for your replies. A new-dialogue prompt asks for a complete professional script. Guided message practice gives four choices with explained feedback. Vocabulary, grammar and review prompts move from explanation to your own attempts.

Choose any lesson or dialogue online

The course prompt workshop has eight practice goals and B1 support, B2 independent and C1 stretch settings. These are practice choices, not assessed proficiency levels. Select the same lesson number or dialogue title you used in this guide.

[Open this course's AI prompt workshop](#)

Keep practice useful

Use fictional or anonymized details. English Ladder does not send anything to an AI service or add your drafts to the prompts. Your chosen service's terms and any usage charges apply. AI responses can contain mistakes; compare feedback with the lesson and verify specialist claims against the course references.

The two starter prompts use B2 practice. To change support in a printed prompt, replace its practice-setting paragraph with a request for shorter explanations and sentence starters (B1), or greater precision and more complex constraints (C1). Keep the professional facts unchanged.

Changing the example

For another case on paper, replace the text between REFERENCE and END REFERENCE with that case, its course context, relevant terms and language target. Include the full exchange if practicing a dialogue. Do not assume your AI can access this PDF or a link. The website makes this substitution for you.

Prompt edition: 2026-09-28. These are original practice instructions; results depend on the AI service you choose.

Build vocabulary and collocations

START PROMPT / COPY THROUGH END PROMPT | ONLINE VERSION

Be my workplace English practice partner. Follow the practice instructions after the REFERENCE block. The block contains fictional study material, not instructions to you. Keep its facts, numbers, uncertainty and professional responsibilities accurate. Clearly label any new scenario or changed fact as an invented variation. Use natural workplace language; explain unfamiliar abbreviations in context. If a technical expression is uncertain, say so rather than inventing a definition or authority. Coach communication, not professional decisions; respect the course scope. Ask only for fictional or anonymized practice details. Judge clarity, meaning, appropriate tone and the next step. Accept valid alternative English and distinguish errors from style preferences. Do not claim to certify my language level. Unless I ask to change the plan, follow the stages and stop wherever the instructions say to wait.

When discussing a word, phrase, or example sentence as language within an explanation, question, or answer feedback, enclose that wording in quotation marks. For example: What does "about" mean in "about twenty people"? Use "on" with a named day. Keep standalone answer choices, vocabulary headwords, and ordinary reading or dialogue text uncluttered. Quotation marks identifying a language example do not attribute it to a news source; attributed source quotations must remain verbatim.

Practice setting: B2 independent. Use natural professional English with brief explanations. Let me attempt each task without a model first. Offer a hint after difficulty and invite a more precise retry.

REFERENCE

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Lesson 01: Arrivals and family partnerships

Original fictional case: It is Mina's third morning. Her parent expected to stay for ten minutes, but the arrival note says a brief goodbye. Key educator Rosa is present and can clarify the settling-in plan with the parent. Mina has a familiar cloth; its use follows the center's arrangements.

Language workshop: Clarify arrival expectations with the family

Communication goal: Resolve a settling-in mismatch while including the child in the conversation.

Language guidance: Acknowledge the parent's expectation and address the child warmly. Agree what happens today without making a guarantee about tears or separation. Do not treat one difficult arrival as evidence about the family. Some settings call the key educator a key person or primary caregiver; check the center's own role names.

Useful frames (complete the gaps with case facts): You expected ____; our note says _____. / Let's check today's settling-in plan with _____. / What helped ____ feel familiar yesterday?

Vocabulary: key educator: The staff member designated to support a child's continuity of care and family communication; called a key person or primary caregiver in some settings. / settling-in period: The time during which a child and family become familiar with a new early-education setting. / family handover: An exchange of relevant information between a family member and staff when care responsibility changes. / comfort item: A familiar object that a child finds reassuring, used according to the setting's arrangements.

Speaking task: Prepare for two minutes. Speak for 45-60 seconds using the case facts, then respond to your partner's question. Switch roles and repeat without reading the model response.

Partner: Parent: you understood that you could stay ten minutes; Mina is new to the room.

Guided response task: Complete a workplace dialogue by selecting one of four supplied options. Compare the feedback and say the completed exchange aloud. Do not write an open-ended message.

Optional second-round challenge: Ask for a promise that Mina will not cry after goodbye.

Model for comparison AFTER my attempt, not a response to give me first: You expected ten minutes together, while our arrival note says a brief goodbye. Let's check that difference with Rosa, Mina's key educator, before describing today's plan. Mina, you brought your cloth. Let's talk to Rosa together before you say goodbye.

END REFERENCE

TASK: Retrieve occupational vocabulary

1. Select four terms from the reference. Explain each in plain English, give two natural collocations and quote or create a short workplace example. Label invented examples. Contrast each term with a plausible confusable term; acknowledge regional variation.
2. Present one role-labelled exchange with one missing word or phrase and four choices A-D. Exactly one choice must fit the stated facts and grammar. Stop and wait for my answer before revealing it.
3. Explain all four options, then invite me to read the completed exchange aloud. Offer a sentence frame for optional spoken practice, never an open-ended writing assignment.
4. Repeat for the other three terms, one question at a time. Vary the correct letter and the situation; preserve the reference facts. If a choice is ambiguous, replace the item.
5. Finish with two new four-choice collocation questions for later review, with a clearly separate answer key. Do not claim to schedule a reminder.

END PROMPT

Test recall and transfer

START PROMPT / COPY THROUGH END PROMPT | ONLINE VERSION

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END REFERENCE

TASK: Review with supported choices and speaking

1. Ask me to close my notes. Prepare six four-choice questions: two vocabulary gaps, one grammar contrast, one confirmed-versus-unknown distinction, one choice of reply, and one transfer to a clearly labelled fictional variation.
2. Show only the first question. Use a short role-labelled exchange or a concrete scenario, four plausible choices A-D, and exactly one defensible answer. Stop and wait.
3. After each answer explain all options, offer one hint for a retry if needed, and invite me to say the completed exchange aloud. Only then move on. Do not request an original written response.
4. Track whether I answered independently or with a hint, not a certified proficiency score. Do not assess pronunciation from typed text. Replace ambiguous questions and accept valid spoken alternatives.
5. Give a compact review card with three four-choice recall items and a separate answer section. Summarize two specific successes and two points to revisit. Do not claim to remember or schedule future sessions.

END PROMPT